Katakana scripts in Japan. Katakana came to be used in the post-Meiji period (1867–1912)to denote words from foreign languages.

We see the same process at work in Korea, which also adopted the Han script at an early stage but supplemented it with local scripts, particularly for use among the ordinary people. The adoption of the Chinese script in Korea is dated to what is known as the period of the Three Kingdoms, from 57 BCE to 668 CE , when the peninsula was ruled by the Baekje, the Silla and the Goguryeo. In the fifteenth century, King Sejong of the Chosun dynasty is believed to have created an entire new phonetic alphabet, the Hangul, which borrows from Chinese characters but is quite distinct as a system. It may be noted that in all the three countries, Chinese continued to be an elite language, with much of classical literature being composed in Chinese. In this sense, Chinese served as a symbol of high culture, much as Sanskrit did in what Sheldon Pollock has referred to as the ‘Sanskrit cosmopolis’, stretching from India and across much of South-East Asia.

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In addition to the influence of the Chinese language and the Chinese version of Buddhism, there were other cultural influences from China in the South-East Asian region. These include building architecture, modes of dress and cuisine. This is also the case with the use of ‘chopsticks’ in these countries, so much so that some scholars even speak of a ‘chopsticks sphere’. In most of South-East Asia, people traditionally ate with their hands, like in India, or used a spoon as a ladle. However, once large-scale Chinese migration to these regions began in the nineteenth century, this diaspora community also brought its cuisine and chopsticks to its adopted countries. It is the later migration which introduced Confucian values and Chinese Buddhist rituals and practices to this region, in particular the cult of Guanyin, the Buddhist female goddess of mercy. But these values did not spill over in any significant manner into the host societies in South-East Asia. It is misleading to claim that the entire East and South-East Asian region is somehow part of a Chinese Confucian value system, as some scholars have done. Such a system is limited to the three countries referred